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China Insurance

Profit alerts lift EPS hopes, but dividends decide the trade; prefer Ping An-H

New China Life's positive profit alert, with 1H26E NP guided at Rmb20.7B to Rmb23.7B ([link](#)), up 40% to 60% oya versus FY26E consensus NP of Rmb30.7B, should support sentiment and EPS revisions for China insurers ahead of the interim reporting season in mid to late August. The market backdrop has also improved, with China's CSI300 index up 7.6% in the 1H26 and the 10-year government bond yield moderating to 1.73% at end-Jun-26 from 1.81% at end-Mar-26. Stronger investment income could therefore drive 1H earnings upside across the sector, particularly for China Life and CPIC, given their larger equity exposure classified as FVTPL. However, we believe the stock market response to profit alerts has become increasingly selective under IFRS-17/9, as a larger portion of earnings volatility is driven by unrealised valuation gains on the balance sheet. As such, investors are likely to focus less on headline NP beats but more on whether stronger earnings translate into higher interim DPS, improving CSM quality and sustained life sales momentum. We prefer **Ping An-H**.

- **Positive profit alerts are helpful, but DPS is the real test.** Based on our estimates, a 10% move in the SHCOMP Index would imply around 46% sensitivity on average to FY26E consensus NP (Figure 4), suggesting the scope for EPS upgrades if equity markets remain resilient. However, unrealised gains both assets and liabilities are not typically a direct source of dividend distribution. We therefore expect the scale of interim dividend increases to be the key earnings-related catalyst, particularly for insurers with strong capital positions and progressive dividend policies.
- **Fundamentals still matter beyond the earnings beat.** H-listed insurers appear inexpensive, trading at 5-7x FY26E P/E with a dividend yield of 4-6%. Into 1H26 results, we expect investors to focus on three issues: whether double-digit life sales momentum can be sustained into 2H26, whether sales quality and margins remain healthy, and whether CSM growth is accelerating as a leading indicator of future core earnings. For non-life insurers, we expect limited surprise, with combined ratios likely around 96% in 1H26. Any upside from non-auto underwriting would be the main area to watch. We are quite optimistic on fundamental upside case especially for Ping An Group and China Life.
- **Prefer Ping An-H.** China's H-listed insurers have underperformed YTD, and Ping An-H's consensus FY26E dividend yield has risen to 6.4%, while we forecast at 6.3%. Given its steady DPS growth outlook, solid life franchise, 36% oya FY26E NBV growth forecast and 11% oya FY26E OPAT growth outlook, we view the current profit alert window as an opportunity to accumulate Ping An-H. China Life-H could also benefit from potential profit alert momentum, especially if accompanied by a DPS hike, while CPIC-H offers a comparable 5.5% yield. Overall, we continue to prefer life insurers over non-life names, with PICC P&C and PICC Group-H remaining our least preferred stocks in the sector.

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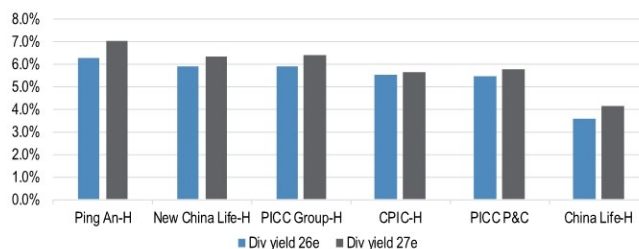
Table 1: China Insurance: Comps table

Rmb per share, HKD per share, x, %

Company	B'berg Code	Rating	Price (13-Jul-2026)	PT (Dec-26)	Upside/downside	P/E 26e	P/E 27e	P/BV 26e	P/BV 27e
China Life-H	2628 HK Equity	OW	27.5	40.0	45%	5	4	1.0	1.0
China Life-A	601628 CH Equity	N	37.7	39.0	3%	18	16	1.6	1.5
Ping An-H	2318 HK Equity	OW	53.3	90.0	69%	6	6	0.7	0.7
Ping An-A	601318 CH Equity	OW	49.5	83.0	68%	6	6	0.8	0.7
CPIC-H	2601 HK Equity	OW	27.4	43.0	57%	5	5	0.6	0.6
CPIC-A	601601 CH Equity	OW	29.6	50.0	69%	7	7	0.8	0.7
New China Life-H	1336 HK Equity	N	43.4	45.0	4%	5	5	1.0	0.9
New China Life-A	601336 CH Equity	N	62.0	59.0	-5%	8	8	1.6	1.5
PICC Group-H	1339 HK Equity	N	4.9	5.8	18%	5	5	0.4	0.4
PICC Group-A	601319 CH Equity	N	7.1	6.9	-2%	11	9	1.0	1.0
PICC P&C	2328 HK Equity	N	14.0	14.0	0%	7	7	1.0	1.0

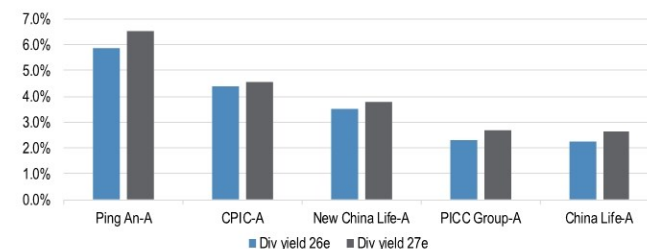
Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. J.P. Morgan estimates. Data as of 13 July 2026.

Figure 1: China H-share insurers: FY26E/27E dividend yield %



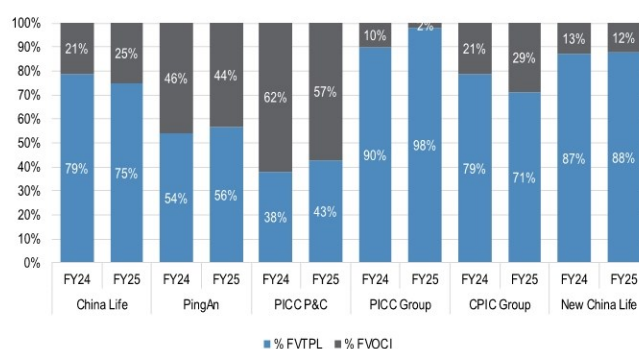
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Figure 2: China A-share insurers: FY26E/27E dividend yield %



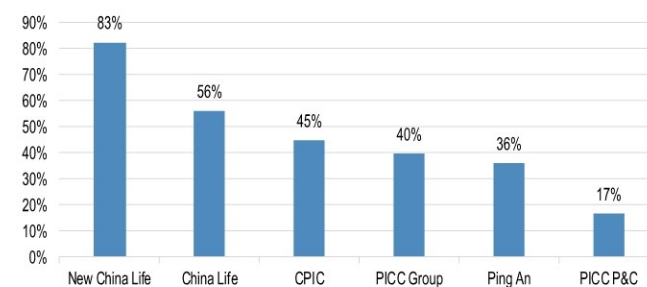
Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. J.P. Morgan estimates. Data as of 13 July 2026.

Figure 3: China Insurance: Equity investment breakdown by accounting classification %



Source: Each company's FY24-25 annual reports, J.P. Morgan calculations.

Figure 4: China Insurance: FY26E consensus NP sensitivity to 10% movement of SHCOMP Index %



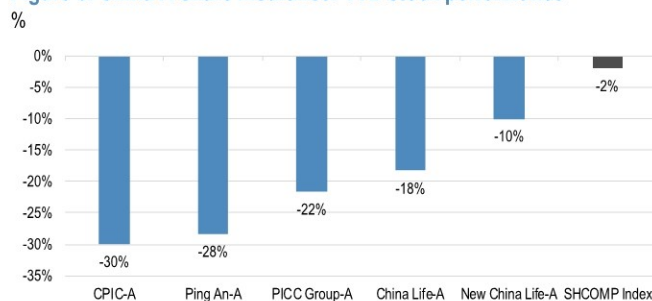
Source: Each company's FY25 annual report, Bloomberg Finance L.P., J.P. Morgan estimates.
Note: Consensus data is as of 13 July 2026.

Figure 5: China H-share Insurance: YTD stock performance



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. Price as of 13 July 2026. Note: Past performance is not an indicator of future results

Figure 6: China A-share Insurance: YTD stock performance



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. Price as of 13 July 2026. Note: Past performance is not an indicator of future results

Table 2: China Insurance: Shareholder return policy summary

Company	Mid-to-long-term capital management guidance
China Life	China Life has proposed an interim dividend of Rmb0.238 and final total dividend of Rmb0.86, implying 16%/18% payout ratio in 2025. In 2024-2026, the company's annual distributable profit in each profitable year will be positive. In compliance with the solvency adequacy ratio requirements of the national laws and regulations, the company's annual dividend amount will be 20-50% of the audited net profit attributable to the parent. Ping An Group has also historically paid out interim dividend. The company has grown cash dividends for 14 consecutive years.
Ping An Group	CPIC affirmed its intention to introduce interim dividend commencing in 2026. Company determines interim and final dividend based on OPAT and investment performance. The initial payout ratio is expected to be set prudently, reflecting management's focus on sustaining both the flexibility and long-term credibility of the dividend policy.
CPIC	PICC Group has proposed an interim dividend of Rmb0.075 and final total dividend of Rmb0.22, implying 13%/21% payout ratio in 2025.
PICC Group	New China Life NCI has proposed an interim dividend of Rmb0.67 and final total dividend of Rmb2.73, implying 14%/23% payout ratio in 2025.
New China Life	PICC P&C has proposed an interim dividend of Rmb0.24 and final total dividend of Rmb0.68, implying 22%/37% payout ratio in 2025.
PICC P&C	

Source: Each company's FY25 annual report and earnings PPT.

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